

What is the difference in the environmental impact of eating beef vs using generative AI?

Posted by u/Fancy_Dog2609 • • 0 points • 23 comments

I know this is an anti-ai subreddit. I am anti-ai. I just want some more perspective. I've also posted this question on a vegan activism page. I want unbiased information. So if you make a claim, please link your source.

Comments

u/memequeendoreen • 2 points • 2026-02-07 01:24 UTC

I would argue that it doesn't matter because a hamburger provides something and generative AI does not. A hamburger has value. An AI video does not. Hope this helps.

u/Organic-Hawk5377 • 1 points • 2026-03-26 17:19 UTC

What are you talking about, ai has the most value of anything ever created: intelligence! My burger gives me a few nutrients for the day, but I've learned things from ai that have impacted my every day life, forever

u/Faith_Location_71 • 0 points • 2026-02-06 11:28 UTC

Lo! Beef is healthy food which helps humans thrive. AI is a dangerous toy at best, and enemy tech at worst. Why compare them? Are vegans that ignorant? Don't answer that. :)

u/JeskaiJester • 2 points • 2026-02-06 13:21 UTC

>Beef is healthy food which helps humans thrive

Brother, you have a department of health and human services to run, why are you on reddit

u/snek_kogae • 2 points • 2026-02-06 10:38 UTC

The emphasis with these comparisons should be on why they're brought up (which is also why i don't yelling "whataboutism" and running away is a good response either)

If the purpose is to say "X is more impactful so everything less impactful doesn't matter", thats silly. It's like the world's small countries who *together* make up most of population insistf China and India do all the work on global issues

If it's to say that you care about a water consuming thing but not a MUCH bigger water consuming thing, it can be annoying, but that in itself is a good question for anyone to ask themselves

If the subject is about reducing GLOBAL water shortages, for example, then focussing on beef is clearly the sane priority, and focussing on a much smaller issue is worse than pointless; it can all but guarantee we don't manage it properly

If they are trying to deflect from concerns around LOCAL environmental impacts, then that's garbage - data Centres are draining water from towns with scarce water for tax breaks, while Collosus for example is poisoning local communities. Focussing on global numbers to ignore local effects is disingenous

As all terminal over thinkers insist: it depends

u/PLMMJ • 1 points • 2026-02-06 15:30 UTC

It is still a whataboutism though, and it is still a lie based on cherry picked data from [a paper on AI water use] (<https://arxiv.org/pdf/2304.03271>). And I always see it used in the context of "You eat hamburgers but criticize AI for its water use! You're a hypocrite!"

u/JunKazama2024 • 1 points • 2026-02-06 09:55 UTC

These comparisons are really interesting.

Almonds are a great example of hidden resource costs and pollution. It takes a gallon of water to grow 1 almond. You can get 40 AI images from a litre of water so what..... 150 images for the water of 1 almond?

Video streaming and social media is another one. It produces 600g carbon to watch an hour long Netflix episode (150g to browse Reddit for an hour instead). You can make 250-1000 AI images for the carbon of that Netflix episode or 62-250 images per hour on Reddit.

u/JeskaiJester • 1 points • 2026-02-06 13:19 UTC

Almond milk is still way better on land usage and environmental impact than dairy. It's the least water efficient alternative milk and it's still using less water than dairy.

u/BlutAngelus • 0 points • 2026-02-06 10:18 UTC

Do you really believe people are growing almond's by the 1's?

No, that makes it much worse. That's the average for one almond and we factory farm them.

u/BlutAngelus • 0 points • 2026-02-06 10:53 UTC

My point was that it's silly when no one is growing almond trees that only produce a single almond.

But, honestly, I just feel like growing produce is a bad comparison for energy consumption compared to AI.

u/JunKazama2024 • 1 points • 2026-02-06 11:39 UTC

Your point doesn't make any sense. It wasn't the water consumption per tree it was the water consumption per almond averaged across all of the almonds produced.

And I think it's a great comparison because we don't need to eat almonds, they're entirely a luxury, we could easily choose to eat foods with much lower environmental impacts but we don't because we enjoy almonds. The same is true for meat of course.

u/BlutAngelus • 0 points • 2026-02-06 13:42 UTC

Let me start this part off with that at first I'm going to be talking about the conceptual side of comparison and then I'll go into the actual practical application:

I understand that. I'm saying it's a bad comparison because the value of one almond being grown vs the tree being grown are entirely different matters. Whether you consider it a luxury or not the value changes entirely based on what is accomplished growing one almond vs growing an almond tree because the end result is not one gallon of water for one almond. It's many more gallons for many more almonds.

An example would be the resources, and the value of the end result, of mowing 5 percent of your lawn vs mowing the entire lawn. When you mow your lawn the goal is not a partially finished job, ideally. **There is nearly no value to when you have only mowed 5 percent of your lawn but there is still a cost.** **That cost would be a negative factor prior to reaching the end result.** Again, I'm speaking conceptually.

Thus, I pose that comparing the resource cost of growing a single piece of produce to generating AI is a false analogy. It puts the idea of growing produce into conceptual territory rather than talking about the reality of energy and resource consumption.

An example; Almond trees produce anywhere from 17,500 almonds at about the lowest to 26,000 at the highest while using 3,000 to 4,000 gallons of water annually.

Math; Almond trees can produce 50-65 pounds of almonds per yield. A pound of almonds is anywhere from 350-400 almonds.

[<https://wikifarmer.com/library/en/article/almond-tree-harvest-yields>]
(<https://wikifarmer.com/library/en/article/almond-tree-harvest-yields>)

Funnily enough. I only meant to calculate this to emphasize the end result has a much different value than the concept of 1 gallon per almond, but this also shows that the "1 gallon of water per almond" is inaccurate. Crazy inaccurate, even.

But let's say it was accurate. So, let's say that almond trees produced 17k almonds and used 17k gallons of water. Then let's compare that to the annual cost of water for an typical AI user while using AI. I don't know what the numbers are, but, even then it's a bad comparison because produce is mandatory. It is almost objectively valued purely driven by necessity. Any produce. AI is not that. Whatever anyone's opinion on what it is or its relevance in the modern day it is not food.

Also, it's important to note, that plenty of other produce items use a comparable amount of water as Almond trees annually. Cherries and Peaches being two. So when you look into it and you start considering that maybe a shit load of water is just part of the cost of doing business to supply people with nutrition it starts becoming very different than talking about luxuries and where we can reduce our environmental impact.

This is why, in practicality, it's a horrible comparison. You compare agriculture environmental impact to other agricultural

environmental impact and what we can do about it there. Not say "Look, this totally optional thing is way less bad than this thing that is not and never will be optional."

As I said elsewhere, factory farming is problematic for many reasons and does cause pollution. But comparing it's cost to AI's cost doth not make any fucking sense.

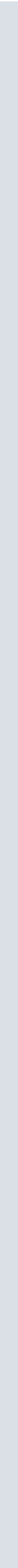
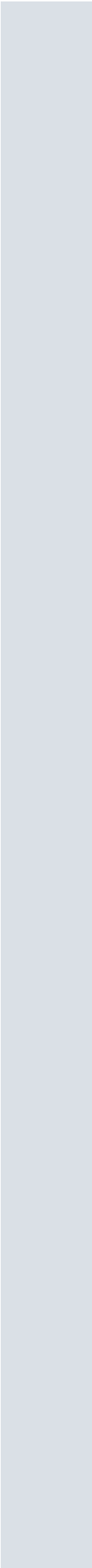
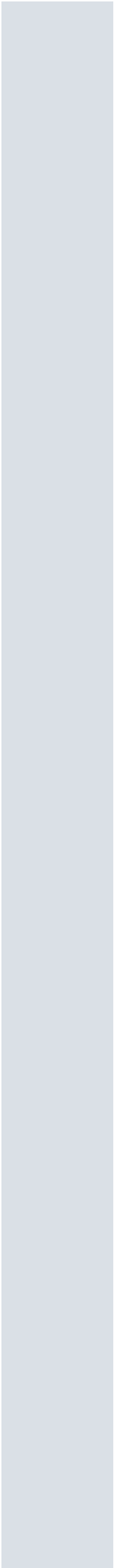
u/JunKazama2024 • 1 points • 2026-02-06 15:25 UTC

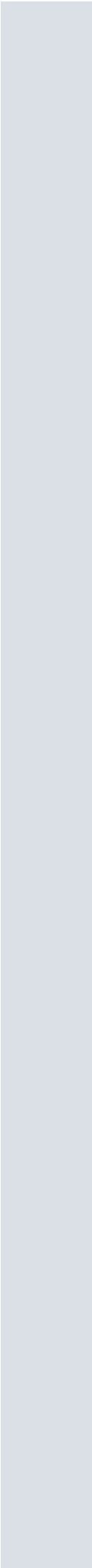
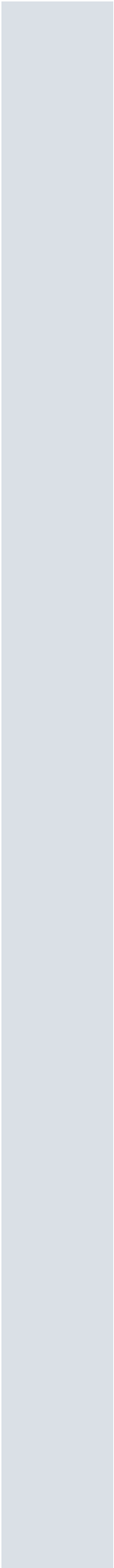
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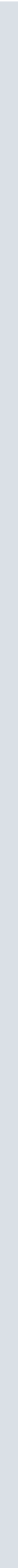
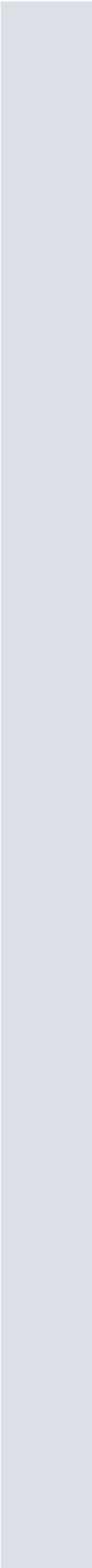
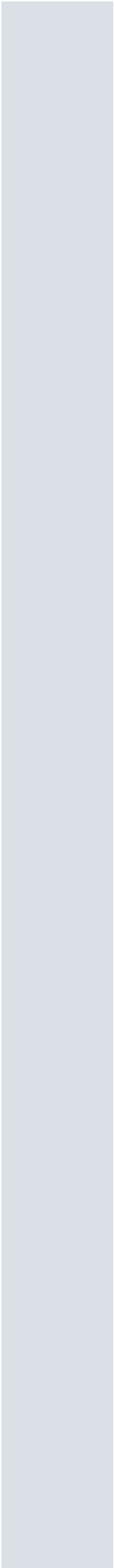
u/BlutAngelus • 0 points • 2026-02-06 15:30 UTC

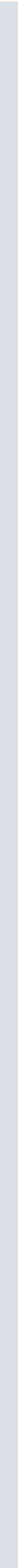
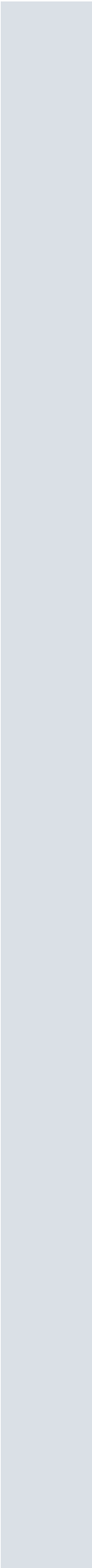
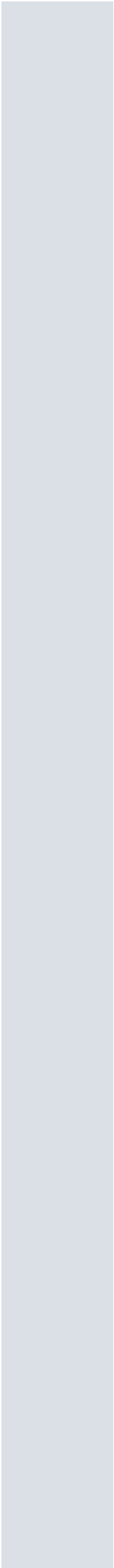
..Even if you disagree with me, I literally pointed out your information was factually incorrect. You are literally the one with no argument. Pathetic.

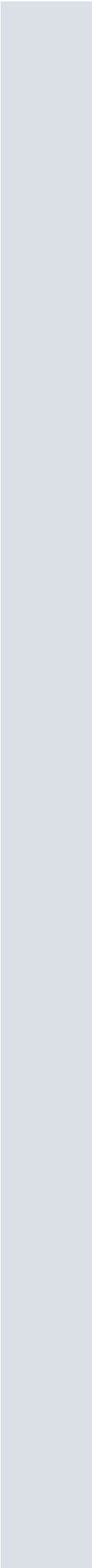
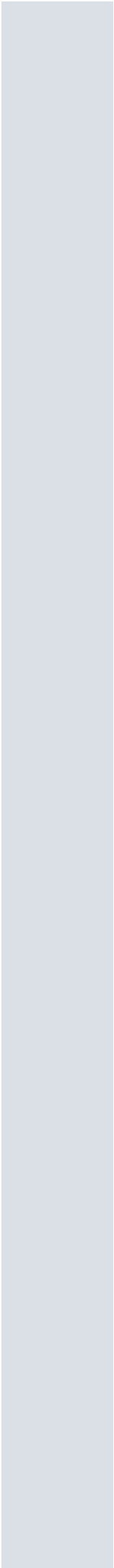
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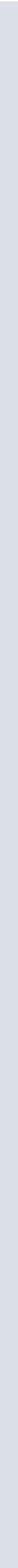
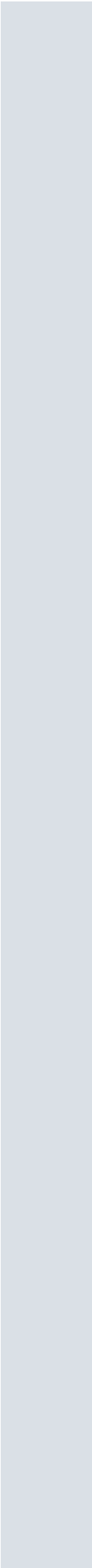
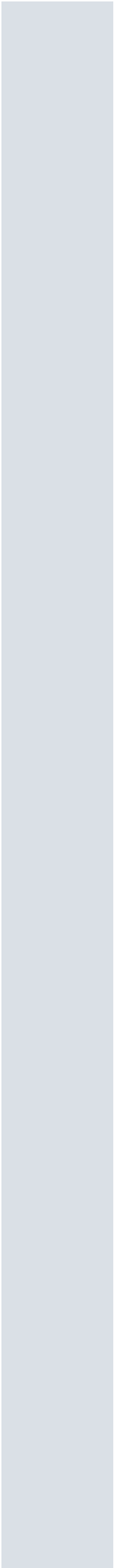












u/Late_Republic_4024 • 3 points • 2026-02-06 08:26 UTC

<https://water.usgs.gov/edu/activity-watercontent.php>

>About 460 gallons for 1/4 pound of beef, or about 1,750 liters per 113 grams

<https://arxiv.org/pdf/2311.16863>

>Each AI image uses about 0.01–0.02 liters of water and 0.00135 kWh of energy.

That puts one pound of beef at roughly 368,000 to 920,000 AI-generated images worth of water.

Yes, beef is really that bad!

u/BlutAngelus • 1 points • 2026-02-06 10:41 UTC

This really highlights why this is a terrible comparison to make.
Because with no thinking and no knowledge it looks bad.

But it's missing important context.

That's calculated for the lifespan of the cow.

It's also including the water used to grow the produce (probably corn) that will be used as feed.

Cows not only produce 100's of pounds of meat but on average produce around 3,500 gallons of milk in a lifetime.

So that water an energy are not going down the drain. They're a conversion of resources to produce a kind of necessity.
INCLUDING the produce that will also be used to make many other products.

You could compare resources from any kind of farming to AI resources and gasp at the number disparity but when you consider what's actually being produced it make a lot more sense.

Not only that, you included a metric for the resource consumption of an entirely different kind product. This being the entire life of the cow and minimized all that comes from it VS a A SINGLE USAGE OF AI TO GENERATE A SINGLE IMAGE.

And, look, if you care about factory farming pollution it's very real and very bad for the environment. But this is not only not that, it's a completely misleading comparison.

If people want to talk about the energy consumption of AI it should be left to comparable mediums.

u/Thor110 • 0 points • 2026-02-06 01:08 UTC

If you don't eat beef, the carbon footprint is the same, I don't need a source for that, I just know the industry won't slow down on production unless everyone cuts down on consumption.

Also, if we allowed cows to gas up the atmosphere with Methane, the environmental impact would be far worse.

u/Cronos988 • 2 points • 2026-02-06 09:01 UTC

Well not consuming beef would reduce the demand for beef, thus changing the price structure, thus, in the long term, the decisions of the producers.

Whether or not this has any practical effect is unknown, but if we allow that uncertainty to invalidate the decision then a similar argument can be made for AI.

For example, I might easily argue that every time I don't prompt the AI, the computing capacity is instead used for training, and thus not prompting the AI has no effect.

u/Thor110 • 1 points • 2026-02-06 09:06 UTC

The impact of an individual would be negligible and would result in near zero reduction of demand.

You could certainly make that argument, though it means very little to me, I am neither pro-AI or anti-AI, both sides of the debate have rational viewpoints worth listening to.